Exposure to Incarceration-Related Events among Children with Jailed Parents

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Background

- Between 1991 and 2007, the number of parents incarcerated in state and federal prisons increased by 79% (Glaze & Maruschak, 2008).
- In 2007, an estimated 809,800 prisoners were parents of minor children in the United States (Glaze & Maruschak, 2008).
- Approximately 2.3% of American children are affected by parental incarceration (Glaze & Maruschak, 2008).
- Children of incarcerated parents are at increased risk of exhibiting behavioral challenges, dropping out of high school, and developing post-traumatic stress disorder, along with other serious mental illnesses (Dallaire & Wilson, 2010).
- These outcomes may be associated with their exposure to **incarceration-related events (IREs) - traumatic experiences related to children's exposure to parents' criminal activity, arrest, and/or court proceedings.**

Research Questions

1. In a sample of children with jailed parents, how many were exposed to IREs (e.g., witnessed their parent's criminal activity, arrest, and/or court proceedings)?
2. Among children who witnessed IREs, what were their common emotional reactions?

Methods

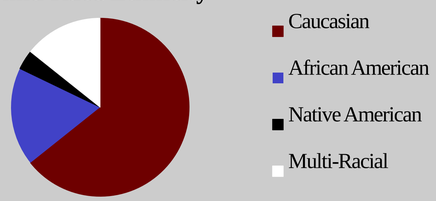
- Data for this study was drawn from a larger, cross-sectional study of parents in two jails in Minnesota.
- Jailed parents and children's caregivers were surveyed about their family circumstances and children's exposure to IREs.
- **Jailed Parents**
  - *Did your child ever witness your criminal activity?*
  - *Did your child witness your arrest?*
  - Participants who endorsed either question were asked to rate how upsetting this experience was for the child using a 5-point Likert-type scale (1=not at all upset to 5=very upset).
- **Caregivers**
  - *Did the child ever witness the parent's criminal activity?*
  - *Did the child witness the parent's arrest?*
  - *Did the child witness the parent's court proceedings?*
  - Caregivers were also asked to rate how upsetting the experience was for the child using a 5-point Likert-type scale (1=not at all upset to 5=very upset).
  - Caregivers were also asked open-ended questions about children's reactions to witnessing these events.

Sample Characteristics

	Jailed Parent (*n*=124)	Caregiver (*n*=28)	Child (*n*=28)
Age	*M*=32, *SD*=7.8	*M*=39.7, *SD*=12.9	*M*=8.2, *SD*=4.03
Gender	M= 88% F=12%	M=4% F=96%	M=39% F=61%
Juvenile Arrest	59%	--	--
Employed*	44%	68%	--

*Pre-incarceration employment for jailed parents; current employment for caregivers

Child Race/Ethnicity

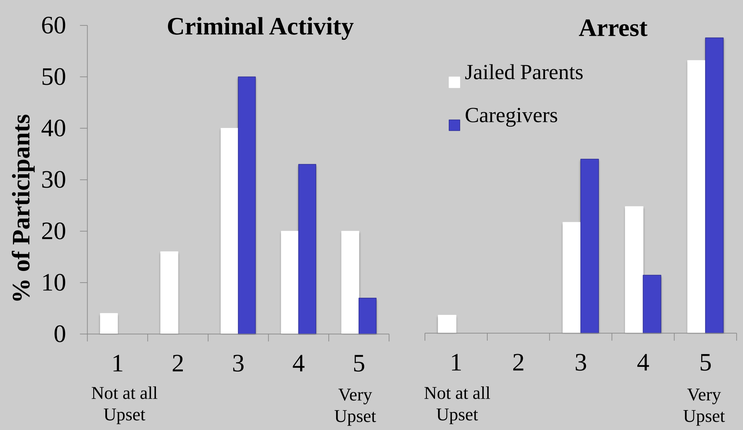


Results

Children's Exposure to Incarceration-Related Events

	Jailed Parents Report	Caregivers Report
Criminal Activity	19%	21%
Arrest	25%	32%
Court Proceedings	--	14%

Children's Distress to Witnessing IREs



- Caregivers' open-ended responses regarding children's reactions:
  - *She started crying and asking where they were taking daddy.*
  - *[She was] upset, scared, sick to her tummy, disappointed and unsafe.*
  - *We all cried, but he was very stoic.*

Discussion

- **One in five** children in the sample witnessed their parent's criminal activity.
- **One in three** witnessed their parent's arrest.
- Reports from jailed parents and caregivers were highly concordant.
- Most often, jailed parents and caregivers reported that children's exposure to IREs was moderately to very upsetting.
- Results have implications for implementation of trauma-informed first response systems. Such systems would allow law enforcement officials to screen children for trauma and offer caregivers and families resources at the time of arrest.
- In an assessment of trauma-informed first response systems, Ko and colleagues (2008) found that police officers were able to decrease children's exposure to subsequent trauma, provide them with containment and structure, and make referrals to providers.
- Local non-profit organizations and state agencies should work on developing arrest protocols taking into account children's needs, encouraging family-friendly visiting policies, and developing training for police officers and correctional facilities that are sensitive to children's needs when a parent is incarcerated.

Limitations

- Data was collected from a small group of children with parents from two jails in Minnesota. A larger and more diverse sample would increase the study's generalizability.
- This data relies solely on the recollection and interpretation of jailed parents and caregivers.

References

- Dallaire, D.H., & Wilson, L.C. (2010). The relation of exposure to parental criminal activity, arrest, and sentencing to children's maladjustment. *Journal of Child and Family Studies*, *19*(4), 404-418.
- Glaze, L., Maruschak, L. (2008, August). Parents in prison and their minor children. (Bureau of Justice Statistics Special Report NCJ222984). Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Justice, Office of Justice Programs.
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